Past Subjunctive

The past subjunctive is the past tense of the subjunctive mood.

The same verbs, emotions, expressions, and conjunctions that require the subjunctive in the present (and future) also require the past subjunctive when referring to something subjective that happened in the past.

Formation of Past Subjunctive

The past subjunctive is a compound tense formed with the **present subjunctive** conjugation of the auxiliary verb (**avoir** or **être**) and the past participle of the main verb.

In English, it is translated the same as the *passé composé* or sometimes as the *plus-que-parfait*, depending on the context.

Avoir as Auxiliary Verb

Donner - to give

J'aie donné	Nous ayons donné
Tu aies donné	Vous ayez donné
Il/Elle/On ait donné	Ils/Elles aient donné

Prendre - To take

J'aie pris	Nous ayons pris
Tu aies pris	Vous ayez pris
Il/Elle/On ait pris	Ils/Elles aient pris

Être as Auxiliary Verb

Sortir - to go out

Je sois sorti(e)	Nous soyons sorti(e)s
Tu sois sorti(e)	Vous soyez sorti(e)(s)
Il/Elle/On soit sorti(e)(s)	Ils/Elles soient sorti(e)s

As with all compound verb forms in French, the past participle in the past subjunctive may need to agree in gender and number with either the subject or the direct object, depending on the auxiliary verb used.

However, when 'avoir' is used, the past participle agrees with the direct object only if it precedes the verb, and only in certain cases.

Examples of the Past Subjunctive

When the Main Clause is in the Present Tense

Français	English
Je doute qu'il **ait rangé** sa chambre.	I doubt he **(has) cleaned/organized** his room.
Nous sommes ravis que tu **sois venu(e)** en Italie avec nous cet été !	We are delighted that you **came** with us to Italy this summer!
Je ne pense pas que Jean **ait aimé** mon cadeau.	I don't think that Jean **liked** my gift.
Il est triste que votre patron vous **ait viré.**	It is sad that your boss **fired** you.

When the Main Clause is also in the Past Tense

Français	English
Je doutais toujours qu'il m'**ait** vraiment **aimé**.	I always doubted that he truly loved me.
Mes amis étaient ravis que je **sois tombé** amoureux de nouveau.	My friends were delighted that I **had fallen** in love again.
Il fallait que tu **sois arrivé(e)** avant tes parents.	You should **have arrived** before your parents.
J'avais peur qu'elle **soit morte.**	I was afraid that she **had passed away**.

Note: The plus-que-parfait subjunctive is an uncertain action done before the action in the main clause. It's very formal and mainly used in French literature. You can use the simple past subjunctive instead.

Remember that the past subjunctive is less commonly used in modern spoken French, especially in informal contexts. However, it is still important to learn and understand, as it appears in written French, literature, and formal settings.